

MESA AI SUMMIT • MAY 18, 2026

Building Career Tools *That Outlast the Semester*



*How a Digital Media Arts faculty member is prototyping a free, local-first,
AI-augmented career dashboard for students to keep after graduation.*

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HELLO

I'm Michelle.

Residential faculty in **Digital Media Arts** at GCC. I started teaching as an adjunct in 1998, joined GCC in 2004 as Director of Instructional Technology, and have been full-time faculty here since 2010.

I also spent time in EdTech product management at a startup in the late 1990s.

MEd from NAU, 2017. My research was on *connectivism* and *personal learning environments*. That's the theoretical foundation under everything I'm showing you today.

28

Years in higher ed

22

Years teaching, adjunct + FT

6

Years in Instructional Technology

1995.

I had just graduated with a degree in **graphic design**. My first day at a Fortune 100 company, a colleague handed me a printout and said:

“Here’s HTML. Learn it.”

He had a server under his desk and the website already started. I learned HTML in a week and we shipped **one of the first Fortune 100 websites on the internet**.

Web design wasn’t a thing when I was in college. I learned a tool that didn’t exist when I was a student. In a creative field, that is not a one-time event. It is the normal condition of the work.

The fundamentals stay.

The tools always change.

Right now my field is changing faster than it ever has, because of AI. So I stopped waiting and jumped in.



Design principles

Grid, hierarchy, typography, color, composition. These haven't moved in centuries. Your students get this in school.



Today's tools

Figma, Adobe CC, Webflow, generative AI. These will look very different in five years. Probably less.



Tomorrow's tools

We don't know yet. Whatever they are, students will need to learn them in a week. Just like I had to learn HTML.

AVC 248, Design Self Promotion

The capstone career-launch course for DMA and Animation students at GCC.

16 weeks. Online, asynchronous. Roughly 24 students per cohort.

Students arrive with a degree's worth of design work in their head and a portfolio in progress. They leave with:

- Polished resume and cover letter
- Portfolio site or reel, presentation video
- Working LinkedIn profile and network plan
- Identity package, business card, leave-behind
- 12 weeks of interview practice + mock interview
- Freelance contract template + spec sheet

All this work lives in Canvas.

And Canvas access ends at graduation.

Canvas • AVC 248 • Spring 2026

Resume_Draft_4_FINAL.pdf

CoverLetter_v3.docx

Identity_Package.pdf

BusinessCard_FINAL_v2.png

Mock_Interview_Recording.mp4

Portfolio_URL.txt

LinkedIn_Strategy_Notes.docx

Freelance_Contract_Template.pdf

...plus 12 discussions, 8 quizzes

The morning after graduation:

Canvas access is revoked.

Discussion threads vanish.

Feedback comments vanish.

Drafts and rubric notes vanish.

What students keep: a folder of PDFs.

“Where do I start?”

The Monday morning after commencement.

They have a degree. They have the portfolio in their head. They have the folder of PDFs.

What they don't have:

- The structure of their semester (which jobs they liked, which they applied to)
- Their cover-letter drafts, interview practice notes, mock feedback
- The weekly habit of “spend two hours on job search” that the course built in them
- Anyone to ask. Their instructor is teaching the next cohort.

*The discipline I spent 16 weeks teaching them **evaporates** in the first week of unstructured time.*

Vibe coding.

I'm a faculty member with a design degree. I built a tool by describing what I wanted.

MY FIRST PROMPT, ROUGHLY

"I'm a faculty member teaching AVC 248, a 16-week capstone career-launch class for Digital Media Arts and Animation students at GCC. I want to prototype a single-HTML-file dashboard students populate during the semester and keep after graduation. It should include:

- a profile and goals section
- a job search log with AI cover-letter generation
- a resume vault with versioned drafts
- a skills tracker with AI gap analysis
- a networking tracker
- an AI interview coach
- a weekly schedule generator

Local-first, no login, first name only. Walk me through the architecture before we write any code."

VIBE CODING, DEFINED

Writing software by **describing intent in plain English** to an LLM and iterating on what it produces. You don't need to write the code, you need to **know what you want** and how to recognize when the output is right.

WHERE THE TERM CAME FROM

*"There's a new kind of coding I call **vibe coding**, where you fully give in to the vibes, embrace exponentials, and forget that the code even exists."*

Andrej Karpathy, co-founder of OpenAI
X post, February 2, 2025

PART 3

Render

A career launch dashboard prototype, designed for students to build during AVC 248 and take with them after graduation.

Prototype · Fall 2026 pilot · singletrackmom.github.io/render

Local-first. No login. Designed to be theirs.

Single HTML file

Vanilla JavaScript. No framework, no build step, no server. The whole app is one file students can save and run anywhere.

Browser localStorage

All student data persists on their own machine. Auto-saves continuously. No account, no cloud, no third party sees their work.

JSON export, JSON import

One click downloads everything as a JSON file. Their backup. Their property. They can move it to any computer, any time.

Claude API (optional)

Live AI features call Anthropic's Sonnet 4 directly from the browser. The student adds their own API key in Settings. Optional.

Copy-prompt mode

Without an API key, every AI button copies the engineered prompt to clipboard. Paste into Claude.ai, ChatGPT, Gemini. Their choice.

FERPA-clean by design

Built so no PII is transmitted. A proposed Career Services pipeline would send anonymous employer data only, via Google Apps Script. Adoption pending.

Three paths through the same tool.

Each one has different time, different goals, different output.

Maya

Brand and graphic design, looking for studio job

HOURS / WEEK

21 hrs

WHERE TIME GOES

Search 8 hrs • Learn 5 hrs • Portfolio 6 hrs •
Network 2 hrs

Riley

*Animation and character design, scaling
freelance*

HOURS / WEEK

25 hrs

WHERE TIME GOES

Client work 10 hrs • Learn 6 hrs • Marketing 5
hrs • Search 4 hrs

Marco

Non-traditional, 3D pivot from manufacturing

HOURS / WEEK

16 hrs

WHERE TIME GOES

Learn 8 hrs • Portfolio 4 hrs • Search 3 hrs •
Network 1 hr

Profile and Goals.

Foundation. Set once, refer back to all semester.

Job Search Hub.

The center of gravity. Students save jobs here every week.

WALK-THROUGH · EVERY OTHER WEEK

Resume Vault.

Four drafts, paced to the course schedule. AI tailoring per job.

Skills, Gaps, and a Training Plan.

Built from the jobs they've saved. Free resources. AI woven in.

The Interview Coach.

A multi-turn AI interviewer that reads their resume and the job.

Weekly Plan and Hour Tracking.

The discipline of the course, ported to self-directed life.

The Final Dashboard.

The page designed for them to open every Monday after graduation.

AI as a coding partner.

A faculty member with a design degree prototyped this in a semester.



PRD first

I wrote the product requirements document before any code. Claude helped me think it through. The PRD is what kept the project from sprawling.



Single HTML file

Vanilla JS, no framework. Claude wrote most of the code. I read every line, tested every feature, redesigned every panel. The faculty stays in the loop.



Daily AI pair-programming

Two-month build. I write the spec in plain English, Claude proposes the code, I iterate. The same workflow my students are about to learn for their jobs.

My stack: Claude Opus 4.7 on Anthropic's \$100/month Max subscription · VS Code · GitHub Pages

A structured tool beats a blank prompt.

An empty AI chat asks the student to already know what to ask. That blank page is where a lot of students freeze, or avoid AI altogether.

A structured tool makes the first move for them. It asks the question, holds their goals and their saved work as context, and turns AI from something intimidating into something they just use.

The interface is the difference between a student using AI with confidence and a student avoiding it.

And building one is not a coding skill. It is prompting. If you can describe what you want, you can do this.

YOUR TURN

What do you build over and over?

Think of one thing you paste into an AI chat over and over. The same prompt, every week.

That repetition is the signal. *That is a structured tool waiting to be built, in your discipline, for your students or for you.*

Take a minute. Drop one in the chat. What is yours?

A FEW MORE, IN CASE YOU ARE STILL THINKING

A few more I am working on.

A STRUCTURED TOOL • LIVE

CopaMigo

A bilingual student-support router. A student describes a problem in plain English or Spanish, and it points them to the right campus service with contact info, hours, and what to ask for.

AN AGENT • AN IDEA I AM
DESIGNING

Syllabus Auditor

Faculty submit a syllabus through a form. An agent checks it against a required-elements rubric, then either logs it as complete or emails back a report with specific fixes.

AN AGENT • AN IDEA I AM
DESIGNING

Canvas Course Auditor

Point it at a Canvas course export and it checks the things I now audit by hand: module-to-competency alignment, accessibility, and how assignment due dates fall across the week.

Testing it for real.

Render is a prototype. The point of the next year is to find out what actually works.

SUMMER 2026

Usability testing

A small group of students works through Render so I can see where it helps and where it gets in the way, then revise before it reaches a full class.

FALL 2026

Pilot in one section

One full section of AVC 248 uses Render across the whole semester. If it works well, the natural next step is adapting it for other programs at GCC.

T H A N K Y O U

Questions?

Reach me:

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Everything's here:

singletrackmom.github.io

Render and these slides are both linked from the main page.